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Sport, media and the fan, 1921 to 2026.

How the internet consumes sport, who gets the credit, and how the people who built the game plug into what comes next.



Ballast · September 2026

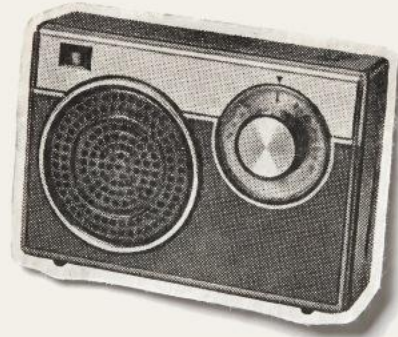
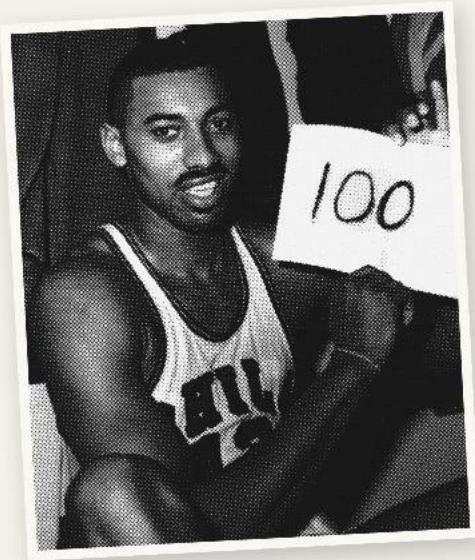
MARCH 2, 1962 · HERSHEY, PENNSYLVANIA

Wilt Chamberlain scored 100 points. 4,124 people saw it. It was not televised, and no film of it exists.

The game survives through a radio recording, one photograph and the people who tell the story. Every athlete holds stories like it. Few have a place to tell them in their own words, to the fans who want to hear them.



Wilt's 100-point night survives as a photograph and a radio recording. LaMelo has been on camera since high school.



1962. 4,124 people in the building. Not televised. What survives is a radio recording of the fourth quarter and this photograph. The league, the newspapers and the networks decided who saw him.



2017 onward. A family reality show and a professional contract in Lithuania at 16. Nearly all of it survives, spread across platforms and mostly unlabelled. The family, then the player, then the platforms decided who saw him.



People now meet sport as a clip, in a feed, often as someone else's remake of it.

The clip

People watch the clip

51% of 25 to 34s and 47% of 18 to 24s say highlights are replacing live games for them. For all Americans it is 38%.

The remake

People remake it

LaMelo Ball's "ion run it" clip is from around 2019. In 2026 TikTok still has pages of remakes, stickers and replies to it.

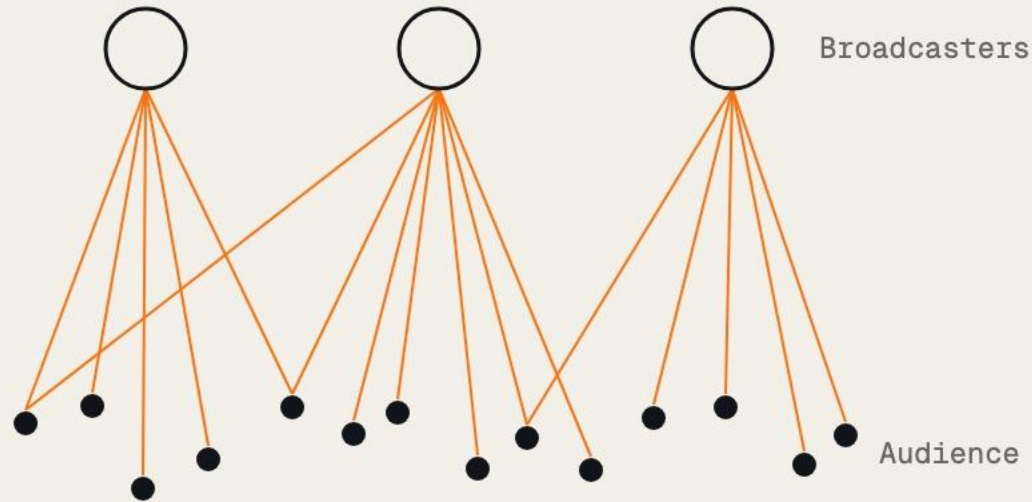
The feed

People find it in a feed

National NBA games are on three services and local games on a fourth. There is no one place where the whole audience meets.

A clip can be reposted a thousand times without once saying who the player is, what game it was, or when.

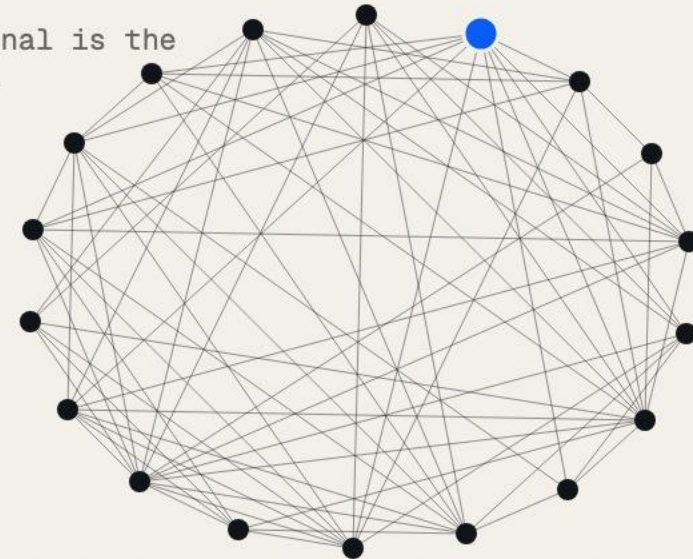
Then



A few broadcasters sent one feed to everyone. The name of the player, the game and the date were on the screen.

Now

The original is the blue one.



Everyone copies from everyone. Reposts, remixes and compilations carry the moment further than the original ever went. None of them has to name the player.

AI does the same thing at machine scale.

What it is made from

Everything already posted

Generative models are built from what is online. A highlight, a quote and a career all go in, and come out without a name on them.

What it can make

Footage

OpenAI put generated video in a consumer app in 2025. It passed one million downloads in five days, and OpenAI closed it in April 2026. Other tools remain.

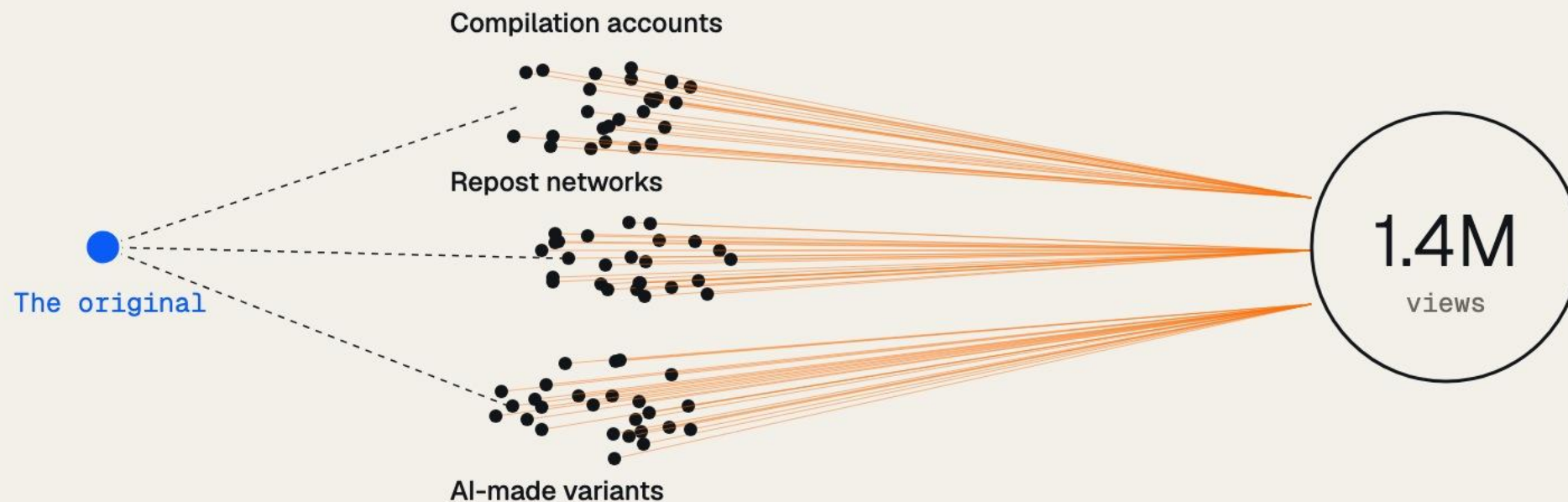
What it cannot make

An original

A generated clip has no author, no date and no source. The real one, with all three attached, becomes the scarce thing.

[This morning, on X](#) A 29-second AI-made video passed 1.4 million views in nine hours. Asked how it was made, the person who posted it replied: “i stole it from a whatsapp group.” Nobody in the thread knows who made it.

A view count measures how far something was copied. It says nothing about who made it or who cared.



Clips get bunched together by association: one player, one theme, one sound. Each bundle adds to the number. With AI tools, making the variants and the accounts that post them is easier than most people realise.

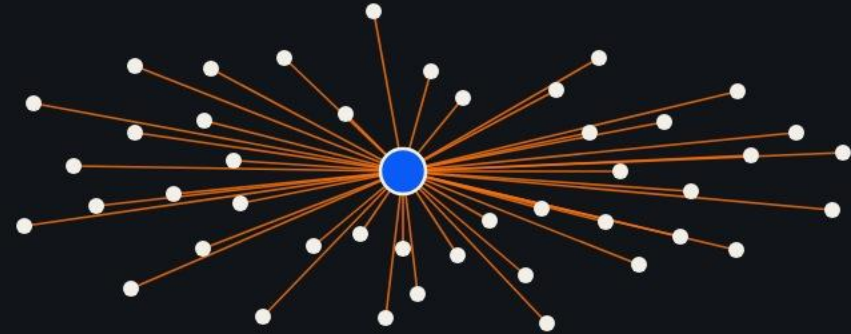
A copy that links back sends people to the original. A copy that does not sends them nowhere.

SAME CLIP, COPIED WITH NO LINK BACK



The copies get watched. The original does not. Someone who sees a copy stays with the account that posted it. A thousand reposts, and the player gains no follower, no visit and no sale.

SAME CLIP, EVERY COPY WITH A NAME AND A LINK



Every copy is a way in. The clip shows the player's name and links to their own account. A thousand reposts become a thousand routes to the player.

One photograph of Wilt's night exists, and it is valuable because it is rare. Nothing is rare now. What can still be worth something is being the place every copy leads to. We have not measured this yet. It is the first thing we would test.

Put the people who built the game at the source of how it is consumed now.



First

Make the original

The athlete tells it in their own words, with their name and the date on it. That account is the source everything else points to.

Second

Make it traceable

Every clip carries its game, date and opponent, in a form that search engines and AI assistants can read, so any copy can be traced back to the original.

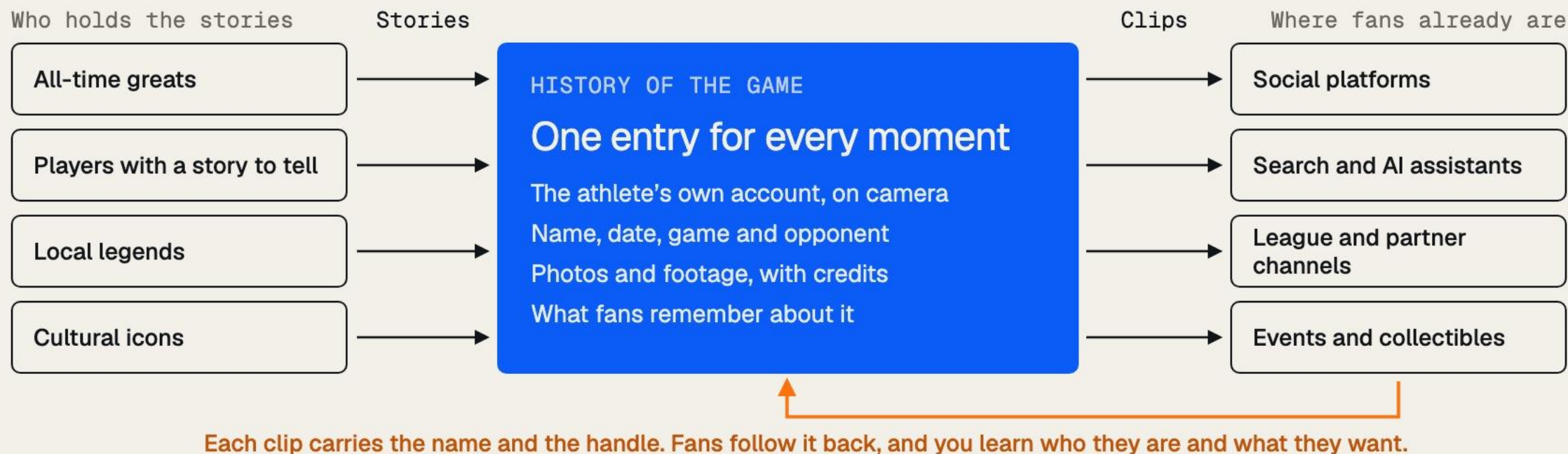
Third

Let it travel

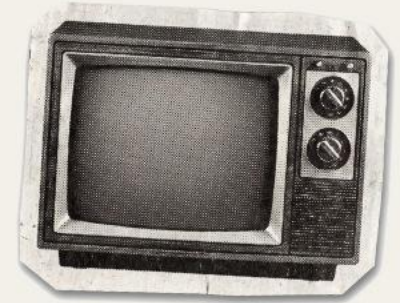
Let fans clip it and remix it with the link back, the way the NBA let its highlights spread. The copies do the distribution. The source keeps the credit.

A career is a legacy that gets passed on. Today it is passed on by whoever clips it. History of the Game can be where it is passed on by the person who lived it.

History of the Game is where the stories are kept, and where every clip leads back to.



Older and younger fans come for different reasons. The same moment can serve both.



The older fan

Has the memory

Watched it happen and remembers the date, the stakes and who was on the floor. Wants to share that, and to hear what the athlete remembers.

The younger fan

Has the feed

Met the athlete through a clip. Learning about players from before your time is one of the best parts of becoming a fan.

Reasons to take part

More than watching

Learning. Sharing a memory. Asking a question. Collecting something. Attending something. Different fans will want different ones.

We do not yet know which of these matter most to which fans. That is a question to test early, with real athletes and real fans.



One athlete, one moment, four weeks.

A small test of one question: will fans go to the athlete for the story, and will they come back?

When	What happens	What comes out of it
Week 1	The athlete records ten minutes on one moment fans already know: what led up to it, what they remember, who was there. We film it and edit it.	The story from the person who lived it, on the athlete’s own account, with their name and the date on it.
Weeks 1–2	Fans reply with where they were that night and what they have always wanted to ask. We collect the replies.	A place to put their memory next to the athlete’s.
Week 2	The athlete picks five of the questions and answers them on camera in one sitting.	An answer from the athlete, to a fan by name.
Week 3	We show fans three things tied to that moment, for example a signed print, a replica ticket, or a seat at a live Q&A. They tap the one they want and leave an email. Nothing is made or sold yet.	A count of how many fans would pay, and for what, before anyone spends money making it.
Week 4	We report to you: how many fans came, how many took part, how many came back, how many wanted to buy, and how many hours it took the athlete.	The numbers to decide whether to run a second one.

Where an athlete’s project could fit into what these institutions already run.

Institution	What it runs today	Where a project could fit
NBA · the app and NBA ID	A free membership since 2022. The app holds 500 classic games and every Finals game since 2000.	An athlete’s own account of a game, next to the full game the league already hosts.
NBA Launchpad	Each year the league pilots emerging companies for six months. In 2026 it chose five from more than 200.	A defined route to a league pilot, ending in a demo day at Summer League.
Retired Players Association	Represents more than 1,000 former NBA and WNBA players. Launched its own storytelling unit in 2020.	Access to the athletes, and a partner that already wants these stories told.
Fanatics and Topps	Exclusive NBA and players’ union trading cards since October 2025, legends included, with authenticated game-worn patches.	Memorabilia tied to a story. The first question is what the exclusive leaves open.
Nike	Wound down its digital collectibles unit RTFKT, faced a lawsuit from holders, and sold it in December 2025.	Interest in athlete stories and archives, caution on digital assets.

For each one we would work out why it makes sense for both sides, what fans get, who handles what, and what needs approval. An athlete controlling their story does not mean they own the footage.

We would like to be the research and development team for History of the Game.

Every week

A short note

What moved in tech, culture and the game, and what it means for you.

Every month

One idea, tested

Taken far enough to put in front of real fans and athletes, with a recommendation.

Every quarter

A review

What worked, what fans came back for, and what to do next.